

THE NECK TATTOO OF THE FINANCIAL WORLD

When my sister was 18, she went into a tattoo parlor and asked for a neck tattoo of a flower. The artist turned her down because she was too young to make a lifelong decision that might affect her ability to work in the future.

Wouldn't it be nice if someone did the same thing for student loans?

Paying for college is marketed as paying for an identity. Think of all the “Harvard Mom” bumper stickers and “UNC Grad 4Ever” T-shirts—the clothing equivalent of neck tattoos you get at 18.

I believed that identity fallacy. So did my sister, who attended a community college in Santa Monica, California, paying out-of-state tuition, when she could have attended the same caliber of school for free at home in Florida.

She ended up coming back to South Florida when she realized Santa Monica was too far away, too expensive, and too unfamiliar. After living with my parents for a while, she enrolled at Tallahassee Community College (TCC). Two years later, she transferred to Florida State University (FSU). But had she just gone straight to TCC from high school, she would have paid almost nothing for that *and* for her eventual transfer to FSU. Instead, my sister has \$30,000 in loans just like I do (and I went to a liberal arts college in Boston). The pressure to go somewhere new, and to do so immediately, got to her too.

As of this writing, my student loans are spread out among three accounts with different student loan service providers. They provide customer service, process payments, or help set up payment plans. Providers are chosen either by you directly (private) or through the government choosing a company like Nelnet or Navient as the provider of the loan (federal).

I have two loans I took out directly with Nelnet (National Education Loan Network) that add up to \$4,000, and I have one with Navient, a student debt